

DATA 202 — Forum 2

Ch. 2 — "How a Number Comes to Be"

Group members (all three names):

1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____

Week 5 — Clustering & Dimensionality Reduction

Stone's argument: before any number exists, someone decides what is worth counting — and people count what they are motivated, trained, or paid to see. Children who seem unable to count clay pellets count M&M's just fine. In the same satellite photos of Rwandan refugee camps, UN officials saw 750,000 refugees and U.S. officials saw almost none. Bond raters paid by the firms they graded gave bad mortgages good grades. And predictive algorithms like PredPol end up counting data they helped create. "Numbers enjoy an aura of objectivity and precision unwarranted by their origins" — to know what a number means, you have to know how it came to be.

Discuss and write a response to each question below (~25 min).

1. Stone argues that we count what we are motivated or trained to see: the invisible gorilla, the fathers that feeding studies barely counted, the satellite "clusters of people" in which UN officials saw 750,000 refugees and U.S. officials saw almost none ("They saw what they wanted to see"). This week you also looked at clusters and decided how many groups there were and what to call them. What shaped your choices, and how could someone with a stake in the result "see" different groups in the same data?

2. When "their rewards hinge on their numbers," Stone writes, people count differently: bond raters paid by the firms they graded, welfare contractors who counted a client's paperwork as a "successful transition to employment." She calls it creative counting — "finagling with the first step of counting: categorizing what counts as a what." Pick a number you are judged by (a grade, a GPA, a performance review, a follower count). How could it be counted creatively without anyone lying, and who loses when it is?

3. Stone’s predictive-policing example “doesn’t predict actual crimes or where crimes will occur. It predicts police behavior.” In her words, “The algorithm causes the numbers it counts to come into being.” This week’s reading traced a similar loop, where a low credit score leads to worse terms and a worse record next year. Choose an algorithm that scores or sorts you (a feed, a recommender, a credit score, an admissions or grading tool). What does it really predict, how might it help produce the data it later learns from, and what could break the loop?

Submission. Photograph or scan your annotated worksheet and upload it to Moodle by **Wednesday of the following week (Week 6)**. See Forum Instructions for the full process.